Lesson 7 — The Bench by the Stairs

Level: B1 (seventh step)

Theme: A student repair bench: rules, faults and judgement

Time: 6 sessions, 50–60 minutes each

Skills: Listening → Reading → Vocabulary → Grammar → Comprehension → Speaking → Writing

New in this lesson: the modals can, could, should, must and have to, the weak can against can't and have to said as hafta, and the state verbs that never take the continuous. The passage stays at about 500 words; the question set is unchanged.

01 · Passage — The Bench by the Stairs

> How to do the listening. The same rule as every lesson so far: the student listens twice with no text, then reads. Audio files: `01-passage.mp3` first, then the other parts in order. Part `05-can-and-hafta.mp3` is new — weak can against can't, and have to said as hafta.

1.1 Before listening (2 minutes, Arabic is fine here)

1. What can you repair yourself, and what must you take to somebody else?
2. What should a person always do before opening a machine?
3. Have you ever had to learn something because nobody else would do it?

1.4 Now read the passage

Passage: The Bench by the Stairs (510 words)

The bench is under the stairs in the engineering building, between a window and a cupboard, and it has been there for two years. Two students sit at it on Sunday, Tuesday and Thursday afternoons. Anyone in the college can bring a machine to them, and about half of the machines go away working.

[A] Maysa started it in her second year. She is not an engineer either — she studies information systems — but she had to learn, because nobody else was going to repair the department's laptops and she could not work without one. She can change a screen now in forty minutes. She says the first year was mostly learning what she must not touch.

There is a list of rules taped to the cupboard door, and the first three are about electricity. You must unplug the machine. You must take the battery out if the battery comes out. You must not open a power supply, ever, because a capacitor inside it can hold a charge for days after the plug is pulled, and nothing on this bench is worth that.

[B] After that the rules are about care rather than danger. Put the screwdriver down and touch the metal frame before you touch a component, so that the static on your hands goes somewhere harmless. Put every screw in a labelled box, because the screws are not all the same length and a long one in a short

hole will go through something. You do not have to be quick. You do have to be able to put it back together.

Most faults are dull to diagnose, which Maysa says is the good news. A laptop that overheats and shuts down usually has a fan packed with dust; you can clean it with a brush and some air, and it will run for another year. A machine that will not start on battery often needs nothing but a new battery.

[C] Some things cannot be mended at a bench under the stairs, and the second skill is knowing which. A broken screen can be replaced if the part exists. A board with a burnt track cannot, not here. A machine still under warranty should not be opened at all, because opening it ends the warranty. When the answer is no, Maysa writes the reason on a card, because a person who knows why can decide what to do next.

[D] They keep a log. Every machine gets a line: what came in, what they tried, what it needed, whether it worked. The log is how they found out that nine of the last twenty overheating laptops had the same fault, and that they should have checked the fan first every single time.

Samir asked her last month what the bench still needs. She said it must have better light before anything else, that they should have a soldering station, and that they could do twice as much with a second person on Thursdays. "But you can do a great deal," she said, "with a brush and a list of rules."

1.5 Read aloud

Read the passage aloud once and record it. Watch the modals as you read: can should be short and quiet, and can't should be long. If they sound the same, slow down and do the paragraph again.

02 · Listening questions

1.2 Listening — first time (no text)

L1. Where is the bench, and who sits at it?

L2. What does Maysa say the first year was mostly about?

L3. Why must you never open a power supply?

L4. What usually makes a laptop overheat?

1.3 Listening — second time (no text)

Write four modal verbs that you heard, and the verb that followed each one. Then write one word you heard but did not understand.

03 · Vocabulary and Lesson 5 recall

2.1 Key words

#	WORD	TYPE	SIMPLE MEANING	ARABIC	EXAMPLE
1	bench	noun	the long strong table you work at with your hands	طاولة عمل	The bench is under the stairs in the engineering building.
2	screwdriver	noun	the tool you turn screws with	مفك براغي	Put the screwdriver down and touch the metal frame first.
3	fault	noun	the thing that is wrong with a machine	عطل	Nine of the last twenty laptops had the same fault.
4	diagnose	verb	to find out what is wrong, before you try to mend it	يُشخّص العطل	Most faults are dull to diagnose.
5	component	noun	one separate part inside a machine	قطعة	Touch the metal frame before you touch a component.
6	static	noun	the electricity that builds up on your body and can kill a chip	كهرباء ساكنة	The static on your hands goes somewhere harmless.
7	capacitor	noun	a part that stores electricity and can hold it after the power is off	مُكثِّف	A capacitor can hold a charge for days.
8	fan	noun	the part that turns and blows air to keep a machine cool	مروحة	They should have checked the fan first every time.
9	overheat	verb	to get too hot to go on working safely	يسخن أكثر من اللازم	A laptop that overheats usually has a fan full of dust.
10	dust	noun	the fine dry dirt that settles on everything and blocks a fan	غبار	The fan was packed with dust.
11	replace	verb	to take an old part out and put a new one in its place	يستبدل	A broken screen can be replaced if the part exists.
12	label	verb	to write on something to say what it is	يضع ملصقاً	Put every screw in a labelled box.
13	warranty	noun	the maker's promise to mend a machine free for a set time	ضمان	A machine still under warranty should not be opened.
14	log	noun	a written record, kept in order, of what was done	سجل	They keep a log, and every machine gets a line.

2.2 Synonyms and opposites

WORD	SYNONYM	OPPOSITE
fault	problem, defect	a clean bill of health
diagnose	work out what is wrong	guess

WORD	SYNONYM	OPPOSITE
replace	swap, change for a new one	keep
overheat	get too hot	cool down
dull	ordinary, not interesting	unusual
harmless	safe, doing no damage	dangerous
label	mark, name	leave blank
under warranty	still covered by the maker	out of warranty

2.3 Expressions to learn

EXPRESSION	WHAT IT REALLY MEANS
packed with	completely full of
go through something	make a hole in it by accident
the good news	the part of the situation that helps you
not here	possible somewhere else, but not with what we have
put it back together	reassemble it so it works again
every single time	on every occasion, without one exception
a great deal	a lot

2.4 Vocabulary practice

A. Write the opposite:

1. overheat → _____
2. replace → _____
3. harmless → _____
4. dull → _____
5. under warranty → _____

B. Which word is different? Say why:

1. screwdriver — brush — bench — warranty
2. fan — capacitor — component — diagnose
3. dust — static — log — heat

C. Say it in your own words:

1. What is a fault, and how do you diagnose one?
2. What does under warranty mean, and why does it change what you may do?

04 · Grammar — modals: can, could, should, must, have to

Come back to: the present perfect continuous

Lesson 5 taught have / has + been + -ing, for how long something has been going on. Two lines to remind you:

I / YOU / WE / THEY	HAVE BEEN WORKING
he / she / it	has been working

New this time: some verbs never take the continuous at all.

A verb that describes an action can be continuous. A verb that describes a state — something that simply is the case, with nothing happening — cannot:

STATE VERB	SAY THIS	NEVER THIS
be	The bench has been there for two years.	has been being
know	She has known about the fault for a week.	has been knowing
own	The college has owned that laptop since 2019.	has been owning
mean	I have meant to ask you for days.	have been meaning
need	It has needed a new fan all year.	has been needing
belong	That screwdriver has belonged to the bench since the start.	has been belonging

The family is small and worth learning as a list: be, have (= own), *know, understand, believe, need, want, like, love, hate, mean, belong, cost, seem. With these, use the present perfect simple* even when you are talking about how long.

A warning: a few of them change meaning and then they can be continuous. I am having a problem is an action (experiencing), not ownership. She is thinking about it is an action; I think it is broken is an opinion, and an opinion is a state.

Quick practice. Simple or continuous?

1. The bench _____ (be) under the stairs for two years.
2. They _____ (keep) a log since the first week.
3. She _____ (know) about that fault for a month.
4. He _____ (clean) fans all afternoon.

Now the modals. A modal verb sits in front of another verb and changes what the sentence is doing: how certain it is, how possible, how necessary, how permitted. The whole family behaves the same way, which is the good news.

3.1 How they work — three rules, no exceptions

RULE	RIGHT	WRONG
No to after the modal	She can change a screen.	she can to change
No -s for he / she / it	He must unplug it.	he musts unplug
Negative and question need no do	Can you open it? / You must not open it.	do you can open

The only one that breaks the pattern is have to, which is not really a modal at all: it is the ordinary verb have, so it does take do, does and did — Do you have to be quick?

3.2 Ability, and permission: can and could

	EXAMPLE
Ability now	She can change a screen in forty minutes.
Ability in the past	She could not work without a laptop.
Possibility	A capacitor can hold a charge for days.
Permission	Anyone in the college can bring a machine to them.
Asking politely	Could I leave it here until Thursday?

Could is the past of can, and it is also the polite present. Both are normal; the sentence tells you which.

3.3 Advice: should

Should is the weakest of them, and the most useful. It gives advice, not an order, and the speaker knows you may do otherwise:

> You should touch the metal frame first.
>
> A machine under warranty should not be opened.
>
> Should I take the battery out?

should have + past participle looks back at advice that was not taken: They should have checked the fan first. They did not, and now they know.

3.4 Necessity: must and have to

Both mean the thing is necessary. They differ in where the necessity comes from, and the difference is real:

	WHERE IT COMES FROM	EXAMPLE
must	the speaker, or a rule the speaker owns	You must unplug the machine. — it is on her list
have to	a fact, a law, somebody else	She had to learn, because nobody else would.

In the past, must has no past tense: you must use had to for both. Yesterday I had to replace the fan, never yesterday I must replace.

3.5 The one that catches everybody

must not and do not have to are opposites, not synonyms:

	MEANING	EXAMPLE
must not	it is forbidden — do not do it	You must not open a power supply.
do not have to	it is not necessary — do it or do not	You do not have to be quick.

Read those two lines twice. You must not be quick and you do not have to be quick are two completely different instructions, and the passage uses both kinds within four lines of each other.

3.6 Grammar practice

A. Choose the right modal:

1. You _____ unplug the machine before you open it. (rule on the list)
2. She _____ change a screen in forty minutes. (ability)
3. You _____ touch the metal frame first. (advice)
4. She _____ learn, because nobody else would do it. (past necessity)
5. _____ I leave the laptop until Thursday? (asking politely)

B. must not or do not have to?

1. You _____ open a power supply. It is dangerous.
2. You _____ be quick. Take all afternoon if you need it.
3. You _____ open a machine that is under warranty.
4. You _____ label the box, but everybody does.

C. Put it in the past:

1. I must replace the fan. → Yesterday I _____ the fan.
2. She can repair it. → Last year she _____ it.
3. They should check the fan. (but they did not) → They _____ the fan.

D. Present perfect simple, or continuous?

1. The log _____ (be) on the cupboard since the bench opened.
2. They _____ (repair) laptops all afternoon.
3. She _____ (know) the answer since Tuesday.
4. He _____ (clean) that fan for twenty minutes.

05 · Weak can, hard can't, and have to

3.7 Weak can, hard can't, and have to → hafta (listen to `05-can-and-hafta.mp3`)

Modals are small words that carry the whole meaning of the sentence, and small words are exactly the ones English swallows. Two traps here, and the first one changes the meaning completely.

1. can is weak; can't is strong.

In a normal positive sentence can is unstressed and its vowel collapses to /ə/. The negative keeps a full, long vowel — and in British English it is a different vowel altogether:

WRITTEN	WHAT YOU HEAR	WHICH VOWEL
I can fix it.	/aɪ kən ˈfɪks ɪt/	short, weak /ə/
I can't fix it.	/aɪ kɑːnt ˈfɪks ɪt/	long /ɑː/
She can come.	/ʃi kən ˈkʌm/	weak
She can't come.	/ʃi kɑːnt ˈkʌm/	long

So you are not listening for the t — in fast speech the t often disappears before another consonant. You are listening for the length of the vowel and for where the stress falls. In I can fix it the stress is on fix; in I can't fix it it is on can't.

Can takes its full sound /kæn/ back at the end of a sentence: Yes, I can.

2. have to → **/ˈhæftə/**, has to → **/ˈhæstə/**.

Before another verb, the v turns into an f — because t is voiceless and the v follows it round:

WRITTEN	WHAT YOU ACTUALLY HEAR
I have to go.	/aɪ ˈhæftə ˈgəʊ/
She has to learn.	/ʃi ˈhæstə ˈlɜːn/
We had to wait.	/wi ˈhætə ˈweɪt/
You don't have to be quick.	/jə ˈdəʊnt ˈhæftə bi ˈkwɪk/

3. must loses its t too, before a consonant: you must not touch arrives as /jə məs nɒt ˈtʌtʃ/.

In the audio you hear each line twice, and then a test: say whether what you hear is can or can't. Get that one right and you will stop agreeing to things nobody offered.

06 · Comprehension — a full TOEFL set of ten

Part A — Multiple choice

> This is a full set of ten, the size of a real TOEFL reading set.

1. (Factual) On which days do the students sit at the bench?

   A. Every afternoon.
   B. Sunday, Tuesday and Thursday.
   C. Thursday only.
   D. Whenever a machine arrives.

2. (Factual) What does Maysa study?

   A. Engineering.
   B. Accounting.
   C. Information systems.
   D. The passage does not say.

3. (Negative factual) According to the passage, all of the following are rules at the bench EXCEPT

   A. unplug the machine first.
   B. never open a power supply.
   C. put every screw in a labelled box.
   D. finish each machine on the day it arrives.

4. (Vocabulary in context) The word "dull" in the passage is closest in meaning to

   A. ordinary and not interesting.
   B. dark.
   C. difficult.
   D. dangerous.

5. (Reference) In the sentence, a long one in a short hole will go through something, the words "a long one" refer to

   A. a long box.
   B. a long screw.
   C. a long screwdriver.
   D. a long wait.

6. (Inference) It can be inferred from the passage that the log is kept mainly because

   A. the college requires a written record.
   B. it proves how many machines they have mended.

C. patterns in it tell them what to check first next time.

D. they need it to claim on the warranty.

7. (Sentence insertion) Look at the four letters [A] [B] [C] [D] in the passage. Where would this sentence best fit?

> Not every answer the bench gives is a repair.

- A. At [A]
- B. At [B]
- C. At [C]
- D. At [D]

8. (Purpose of a paragraph) Why does the writer mention the capacitor?

A. To show how much Maysa knows about electronics.

B. To explain why one of the rules is absolute.

C. To warn the reader against buying cheap power supplies.

D. To describe how a laptop is built.

9. (Purpose of the whole passage) What is the writer's main purpose in the whole passage?

A. To teach the reader how to repair a laptop.

B. To describe how a small student repair bench works, and the judgement it takes to run one.

C. To argue that the college should pay for a workshop.

D. To compare two ways of cooling a computer.

10. (The writer's attitude) Which word best describes the writer's attitude towards Maysa and the bench?

A. Sentimental.

B. Admiring.

C. Critical.

D. Amused.

Part C — Fill in the blanks

Use these words. There are two extra words you will not need.

> capacitor · fault · warranty · component · log · dust · diagnose · static · bench

1. A _____ can hold a charge for days after the plug is pulled.
2. Touch the metal frame first, so the _____ on your hands goes somewhere harmless.
3. The fan was packed with _____.
4. Nine of the last twenty laptops had the same _____.
5. They keep a _____, and every machine gets a line in it.
6. A machine still under _____ should not be opened.

7. Put the screwdriver down before you touch a _____.

Part D — Summary

Write the story in two sentences only. Use must or must not once, and can or cannot once.

> Sentence 1 — what the rules at the bench are for: _____ Sentence 2 — what the bench can and cannot mend: _____

07 · True / false

Part B — True / False

Write T or F. If it is false, write the correct sentence.

1. Maysa trained as an engineer. ____
2. You must take the battery out if it comes out. ____
3. You have to work quickly at the bench. ____
4. A board with a burnt track can be mended at the bench. ____
5. The log showed that nine of twenty overheating laptops shared a fault. ____
6. Maysa says better light matters less than a soldering station. ____

08 · Speaking

5.1 Speaking (record each answer, 45 seconds)

1. Tell the story of the bench in your own words. Use must, must not and can.
2. Give three rules for something you know how to do. Use must, must not and should.
3. Describe something you had to learn because nobody else would do it.

Useful sentence starters:

Before you ____, you must ____.

You must never ____, because ____.

You don't have to ____, but you should ____.

I had to ____, because ____.

We can ____ here, but we can't ____.

09 · Writing — How to Do It Properly

5.2 Writing — "How to Do It Properly" (14–16 sentences)

Model answer (copy the shape, change the words):

> I want to explain how to look after a laptop that has to work in a hot room. First, you must keep the air moving. You should never stand it on a bed or a cushion, because the fan takes its air from underneath and soft things close the hole. Second, you have to clean it. Once or twice a year you should open the bottom panel and take the dust out of the fan with a soft brush. You must unplug it and take out the battery before you start, and you must not touch a component before you have touched the metal frame, because the static on your hands can kill a chip you cannot even see. You do not have to be fast. You do have to put every screw back in the hole it came out of, so label the boxes. If the machine is still under warranty you must not open it at all; you should take it back instead, because opening it ends the cover. I have had this laptop for three years and I have known about its fan since the first summer. It overheated twice before I learned any of this. It has not overheated since.

Checklist before you send it:

- [ ] I used must and must not correctly, for rules and for things that are forbidden.
- [ ] I used do not have to at least once, and it means not necessary.
- [ ] I used should at least three times, for advice.
- [ ] I used can or cannot at least twice, for what is possible.
- [ ] I used a state verb in the present perfect simple, not continuous.
- [ ] I used at least 5 new words from Session 2.
- [ ] I used at least 2 words from Lesson 5 or Lesson 6.
- [ ] My text has 14–16 sentences.

10 · Review

6.1 Listen again (no text)

1. Name three rules from the list on the cupboard door.
2. Why does Maysa write the reason on the card when the answer is no?

6.2 Mini-quiz (12 marks)

1. Which modal gives advice rather than an order? _____
2. Must has no past tense. What do you use instead? _____
3. What is the difference between must not and do not have to? _____
4. In speech, have to before another verb sounds like _____
5. The opposite of overheat is _____
6. To find out what is wrong before you mend it is to _____
7. A written record, kept in order, of what was done is a _____
8. Name two verbs that never take the continuous. _____
9. Write a sentence with must not about something dangerous.
10. Write a sentence with had to about last week.
11. Write one sentence with warranty.
12. Tell the story of the passage in two sentences, from memory.

6.3 Lesson 7 self-report

QUESTION	ANSWER
Minutes studied this week	
Hardest part (listening / reading / vocabulary / grammar / speaking / writing)	
Modal sentences I can now make without thinking	
Words from Lesson 5 I have forgotten	
One thing I want to repeat next week	

11 · Answer key and teacher notes

Listening: L1 — under the stairs in the engineering building; two students, on Sunday, Tuesday and Thursday afternoons · L2 — learning what she must not touch · L3 — a capacitor inside can hold a charge for days after the plug is pulled · L4 — a fan packed with dust

Part A (MCQ): 1-B · 2-C · 3-D · 4-A · 5-B · 6-C · 7-C · 8-B · 9-B · 10-B

Why 7 is [C]: the sentence says that some of what the bench produces is not a repair, and only the paragraph after [C] is about the machines they turn away — the burnt board, the one under warranty, the card with the reason on it. The paragraph after [A] is Maysa's own history, after [B] the rules of care, after [D]** the log.

Why 8 is B**: the capacitor is given so that the rule stops being arbitrary. Every other rule on the list can be bent; that one cannot, and the capacitor is why. It is not there to show off her knowledge or to sell anything.

Why 9 is B**: the passage teaches no repair you could actually carry out, asks the college for nothing, and compares nothing. It describes how the bench is run, and most of its detail is about judgement — what to check first, what to refuse.

Why 10 is B, admiring: not sentimental, which is the trap. Sentimental writing would call her brave or the bench a lifeline. This writer gives her the last word, reports the rules without comment, and records that only half of the machines go away working. Admiration shown by accurate detail is still admiration, and TOEFL wants the stronger, narrower word.

Part B (True/False):

1. F — She studies information systems, and had to learn repair herself.
2. T
3. F — You do not have to be quick; you do have to be able to put it back together.
4. F — It cannot be mended there. A broken screen can be, if the part exists.
5. T
6. F — She says it must have better light before anything else.

Part C (Fill in the blanks): 1. capacitor · 2. static · 3. dust · 4. fault · 5. log · 6. warranty · 7. component (Extra words: diagnose, bench)

2.4 A (Opposites): 1. cool down · 2. keep · 3. dangerous · 4. unusual / interesting · 5. out of warranty

2.4 B (Odd one out): 1. warranty (the others are things on the bench) · 2. diagnose (the others are parts) · 3. log (the others are things that build up or come out of a machine)

Come back to (simple or continuous): 1. has been — be is a state verb · 2. have been keeping · 3. has known — know is a state verb · 4. has been cleaning

3.6 A (choose the modal): 1. must · 2. can · 3. should · 4. had to · 5. Could

3.6 B (must not or do not have to): 1. must not · 2. do not have to · 3. must not · 4. do not have to

3.6 C (past): 1. had to replace · 2. could repair · 3. should have checked

3.6 D (simple or continuous): 1. has been — state verb · 2. have been repairing · 3. has known — state verb · 4. has been cleaning

Mini-quiz: 1. should · 2. had to · 3. must not is forbidden; do not have to is simply not necessary · 4. hafta · 5. cool down · 6. diagnose · 7. log · 8. any two of: be, know, own, understand, believe, need, want, like, mean, belong, cost, seem · 9–12. teacher judgement

Teacher Notes

What changed from Lesson 6, and what deliberately did not. 510 words against Lesson 6's 504 — the plateau is holding, and it is meant to. The difficulty this week is in the grammar and in the vocabulary, which is the most technical the course has used: capacitor, static, component, diagnose, warranty. The question set is untouched for the second lesson running. By now she should not have to read the question labels at all.

The one real difficulty. Section 3.5, and nothing else comes close. must not and do not have to look like a negative pair and are not: one forbids, the other releases. Arabic marks these with different constructions, so the error is not a translation error — it is a false friend created by English's own symmetry. The passage was written so that both land within four lines of each other (you must not open a power supply / you do not have to be quick), which gives you a natural place to stop and ask her which is which. If only one thing survives this lesson, make it that.

The second difficulty, which is quieter. Must has no past. Students who have learned must well will write yesterday I must replace the fan for months. 3.6 C drills it; so does the speaking question about something she had to learn.

Why the pronunciation part is the one to protect. Can and can't are the only pair in English where mishearing one word reverses the whole sentence, and the difference is not the t — in connected speech the t usually disappears before a consonant. It is the vowel length and the stress: /kən/ unstressed against /kɑːnt/ long and stressed. A student listening for the t will keep agreeing to things nobody offered. The hafta / hasta section is easier and pays off immediately in listening.

On the "Come back to" section. Lesson 5 taught the present perfect continuous and did not say that a whole family of verbs refuses it. I have been knowing him for a year is a very durable error. The list is short enough to learn outright, and the passage supplies two natural models in its first paragraph — it has been there for two years — which is a state verb in the simple, exactly where a student would want the continuous.

Why this story. Modals are the grammar of rules, permission and judgement, so the passage had to be somewhere with rules. A repair bench gives all five modals real work in one setting: what you can do, what you could do with more, what you should do, what you must do, what you must not do, and what somebody had to learn. It is also the most technical passage so far, which is where the difficulty has moved now that the length has stopped moving.

Success criteria for Lesson 7. The student should be able to:

- answer L1–L4 correctly on the second hearing;
- hear we can't replace that and not write we can;

choose between must not and do not have to and explain the difference;

use had to for past necessity, never must;

use should have + past participle for advice that was not taken;

use a state verb in the present perfect simple without reaching for the continuous;

use 10 of the 14 key words in her own sentence;

write 14 sentences of instructions with fewer than 4 modal errors.

If it is too easy: add may, might and be able to to the family, and ask her to rewrite the bench's rules as polite requests for a customer-facing help desk. If it is too hard: teach must / must not / should only this week and leave have to for a second pass. Do not cut part 05, which is worth more than any of the written work here.

A note on spaced recall. `03-vocabulary.mp3` ends with five Lesson 5 words — battery, repair, install, program, delete. Lesson 6 recalled Lesson 4, so the two-lesson gap holds. Lesson 6's words are due back in Lesson 8.

A note on the games. Five again: crossword, word search, memory pairs, criss-cross and cryptogram, all built from this lesson's own vocabulary. The cryptogram is worth setting as the last one, a week after the lesson: the words are long and technical this time (capacitor, screwdriver, component), so the spelling drill is doing real work.